CSIS KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Tuesday, November 10, 2026 No. 230 11 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. North Korea tested a new high-speed torpedo and announced early-2027 Navy deployment, the weapon's second test in a month.
2. Seoul's Cabinet approved expanding the Cheonghae anti-piracy unit's operational zone closer to the Strait of Hormuz.
3. President Lee Jae-myung called for bipartisan US congressional outreach after Democrats swept the midterm elections.

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,239.13	1,339.19	$90.71	39%	Nov 8	3.00%
+4.4%	−1.7%	−2.0%	flat Oct 27-29	2 days ago	Oct 2026

01 TOP STORIES

NK News / Korea Times / Bloomberg, DPRK

North Korea tests new high-speed torpedo, announces early-2027 Navy deployment

North Korea's Academy of Defense Sciences, Missile Administration, and Torpedo Weapon Research Bureau jointly tested a "new-type high-speed torpedo weapon system" on Monday, with KCNA announcing the weapon will be equipped by the Navy from the beginning of 2027.

The test is the second public test of the weapon in a month; the first was disclosed after an October 15 test. KCNA released no photographs and fewer technical details than the initial disclosure.

Korea Herald / Yonhap, US-Korea

Seoul Cabinet approves Cheonghae unit expansion toward Hormuz; Assembly consent next

The motion, submitted to the National Assembly, where the ruling Democratic Party holds a majority, also adds "support for the restoration of freedom of navigation" to the unit's mandate. Iran's foreign ministry had urged Seoul on Monday to refrain from deployment to the Hormuz area; Seoul reiterated its "non-involvement, non-intervention" principle.

Yonhap / Korea Herald, US-Korea

Lee calls for bipartisan US congressional outreach after Democratic midterm sweep

President **Lee Jae-myung** told a Cabinet meeting that South Korea must maintain close cooperation with the US administration while "establishing a bipartisan foundation for cooperation in Congress" following the Democratic Party's seizure of both chambers in last week's midterm elections.

Lee instructed officials to prepare scenario-based responses to external uncertainties and to minimize negative effects on the domestic economy. Pro-Korea Democratic lawmakers are emerging as frontrunners to chair key House and Senate foreign affairs and security committees, according to Paijinancial News.

NK News, DPRK

Kim Yo Jong rejects UN Secretary-General's inter-Korean dialogue call, threatens consequences

Kim Yo Jong accused UN Secretary-General **Antonio Guterres** of taking a "prejudiced and irresponsible attitude" and "echoing the ROK's unilateral and provocative sophism" after Guterres called for renewed inter-Korean dialogue following a Demilitarized Zone landmine incident.

In her statement, Kim warned that if "reckless military provocations of the ROK gangsters lead to an undesirable incident in the southern border area," the UN Secretary-General would bear responsibility. The statement was also carried by Reuters.

02 OVERNIGHT

Yonhap, US-Korea

IAEA chief welcomes South Korea's nonproliferation commitment on nuclear submarines

IAEA's Grossi met ROK vice FM Jeong Yeon-doo; welcomed Seoul's safeguards pledge.

Yonhap, ROK Economy

South Korea's Financial Security Institute hacked; financial firms' security data leaked

Breach detected Nov 9; FSI notified the Financial Services Commission.

NK News, DPRK

Democrats can limit Trump-Kim deal scope but cannot block a summit, analysts say

New Congress can push back on joint drill reductions and OPCON transfer acceleration.

NK News, NK-Russia-China

Russian visits to North Korea flat in Jan-Sep 2026 despite record Q3 surge

7,499 Russian visitors Jan-Sep 2026, same as 2025; Q3 alone hit 3,876, a record.

Bloomberg, ROK Economy

KOSPI surges 4.4% as chipmakers rally on dip buying

Samsung and SK Hynix led the rebound after prior session's AI-related selloff.

businesspost.co.kr, ROK Economy

Bank of Korea Governor Shin Hyun-song named BIS payments committee chair, first non-Western appointee

Three-year term chairing the CPMI; first non-US/European chair in the committee's history.

NK News, DPRK

Seoul confirms custody of drifting North Korean fishing vessel taken Nov 3

Ministry of Unification confirmed custody; defection intent and crew size undisclosed.

03 PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

No public appearance today, last seen 2 days ago

No KCNA watch flag. 6 provocations logged in the last 7 days.

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

Yonhap / KCNA, DPRK state media, Kim Jong Un

Kim Jong Un stresses importance of agriculture, vows to improve rural life

KCNA reported Kim Jong Un emphasized agricultural work and pledged to improve living conditions in rural areas, continuing the domestic welfare messaging that has led state media for the past several days.

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Kim Yo Jong, Vice Department Director, Central Committee, Workers' Party of Korea

Issued a public statement rejecting UN Secretary-General Guterres' call for inter-Korean dialogue, accusing him of siding with Seoul over the DMZ landmine dispute and warning of consequences for ROK 'military provocations.'

> **Bottom line:** State media confirmed a new high-speed torpedo test with an early-2027 deployment timeline, Kim Yo Jong attacked the UN Secretary-General over the DMZ mine dispute, and domestic content continued to focus on agriculture and welfare, with all recent weapons tests remaining absent from internal DPRK news.

04 | ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Tuesday, November 10, 2026

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

FM Cho Hyun

Korea-France FM bilateral at G7 Paris; Korea-Saudi and Korea-Egypt bilaterals also held

FM **Cho Hyun** held bilateral meetings with French FM Jean-Noël Barrot, Saudi FM Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud, and Egyptian FM Badr Abdelatty on the sidelines of the second G7 Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Paris. With France, ministers reviewed the 140th-anniversary upgrade to 'global strategic partner' status; with Saudi Arabia, agreed to expand cooperation in nuclear energy, advanced technology, and defense.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**
Reported **Foreign Ministry**

MINISTRY OF UNIFICATION

Unification Minister Chung Dong-young

MOU announces Nov 16-17 international seminar on Korean Peninsula peace regime and peace economy

The Unification Ministry and the Korea Research Council for the Humanities and Social Sciences will co-host a two-day international seminar on November 16-17 at the Westin Chosun Seoul, with Unification Minister **Chung Dong-young** delivering congratulatory remarks at the opening session.

Primary **Unification Ministry**

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Lee Yong-cheol NOMINATED

Minister of Justice (nominee)

President Lee Jae-myung nominated **Lee Yong-cheol**, currently director of the Defense Acquisition Program Administration, as justice minister nominee. Lee's confirmation hearing preparation team begins work November 11; his anticipated stance on prosecution-withdrawal of pending cases has drawn intense media scrutiny.

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Democratic Party moves to pass anti-stock-price-suppression bill in current regular session

Full Assembly (ruling Democratic Party caucus)

The Democratic Party announced at its policy caucus that it will pass the inheritance and gift tax amendment, aimed at preventing major shareholders from deliberately suppressing share prices, within the current regular session, with a floor vote targeted before year-end. Internal divisions on the precise formula remain unresolved.

Assembly Speaker Jo Jeong-sik asked to convene Nov 12 plenary for key bills

National Assembly (plenary)

The Democratic Party formally requested Assembly Speaker **Jo Jeong-sik** schedule a November 12 plenary session to process the Democratic Service Members Honor Act, three housing supply bills, and other contested legislation.

05 | US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts Section 232	**15%** Reduced
Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page; no rate changed since the last issue.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50% and automobiles at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, leaving no baseline reciprocal tariff in force. Section 301 investigations launched March 11 against South Korea and 15 other partners are now the primary vehicle for any new tariff action.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding, $200B strategic sectors, $100B energy purchases; no official drawdown figure reported to date.

06 | CAPITOL HILL

Businesskorea, Statement

Democratic control of Congress adds regulatory risk for Korean exporters

Analysis finds Democratic majorities are likely to pursue stricter data-privacy, climate, and supply-chain regulations that could increase compliance costs for South Korean exporters, even as they are more receptive on alliance matters and less likely to threaten tariff increases for political leverage.

Chosun Ilbo, House, Statement

Korean-American Rep. Young Kim loses fourth-term bid in midterms

Rep. Young Kim, a Korean-American Republican who co-chaired the Congressional Caucus on Korea and was a vocal advocate for the US-ROK alliance, lost her reelection bid, removing a key bipartisan Korea voice from the House.

07 | NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

Foreign Ministry, Japan-Korea, Primary

Korea-Japan Kansai economic forum in Osaka focuses on energy partnership and economic security

The 18th Korea-Japan Kansai Economic Forum convened in Osaka, with MOFA's director-general for bilateral economic diplomacy stressing that economic security is the "core axis" of an upgraded Korea-Japan partnership and calling for supply-chain cooperation with like-minded countries. The forum, held annually since 2008, addressed carbon neutrality and energy supply-chain resilience.

08 KOREA AND THE WORLD

Korea JoongAng Daily, Europe, Diplomacy

Korea and France deepen strategic partnership at G7; FM meeting addresses Ukraine aid

FM Cho Hyun met French FM Jean-Noël Barrot on the sidelines of the second G7 Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Marseille, reviewing the 2026 upgrade of bilateral ties to 'global strategic partner' on the 140th anniversary of diplomatic relations. Ministers also discussed Korea's planned $100 million Ukraine aid commitment.

Korea JoongAng Daily, Ukraine, Aid

Seoul to commit $100 million in Ukraine aid despite diplomatic tensions

South Korea plans to announce a $100 million Ukraine aid package, maintaining its support despite ongoing diplomatic friction; the commitment aligns with the Lee government's stated position supporting Ukraine while Seoul avoids direct lethal weapons transfers.

RBC-Ukraine, Europe, Defense exports

Poland receives new batch of South Korean K2 tanks and K9 howitzers for eastern flank

A new delivery of Korean-made K2 main battle tanks and K9 self-propelled howitzers arrived in Poland, continuing deliveries under the 2022 framework arms deal; Poland is among the largest customers of South Korean defense hardware in NATO's eastern flank.

09 BUSINESS & ECONOMY

Hankyoreh

Korea's three major telecoms accelerate AI data center buildout as core business matures

All three carriers reported AI data center revenue growth, with LG Uplus up 27.7% and KT Cloud up 7.7%.

KT SK Telecom LG Uplus

Dong-A Ilbo

Samsung prepares Korean launch of AI smart glasses developed with Google; preorders begin Nov 12

Samsung Electronics' "Intelligent Eyewear", developed with Google's Gemini AI and eyewear brands Gentle Monster and Warby Parker, will begin preorders in South Korea and the United States on November 12, ahead of a December retail launch. The launch targets the smart glasses market where Meta holds an estimated 85.2% share.

Samsung Electronics Google Gentle Monster

YTN

Korea's top-10 firms account for record 61% of total trade, semiconductor concentration driving figure

Korea's trade concentration ratio for its 10 largest companies reached 61%, the highest on record, with semiconductor exports cited as the primary driver. The figure reinforces supply-chain vulnerability discussions ahead of Section 301 tariff determinations.

Samsung Electronics SK Hynix

10 UPCOMING

NOV 12

Samsung smart glasses preorders open in Korea and US

Samsung's AI-powered Intelligent Eyewear, co-developed with Google and Gentle Monster / Warby Parker, begins taking preorders November 12 ahead of a December launch.

NOV 16

MOU international seminar on peninsula peace regime opens

The Unification Ministry and Korea Research Council for Humanities and Social Sciences co-host a two-day international seminar on the Korean Peninsula peace regime and peace economy at the Westin Chosun Seoul, November 16-17.

11 | ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

FM Cho Hyun (@FMChoHyun), November 9

"Met Saudi FM Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud on the sidelines of the G7 Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Paris on November 9. Ministers agreed to continue high-level exchanges and to further expand substantive cooperation in nuclear energy, advanced technology, and defense. Both sides agreed that restoring freedom of navigation based on international law in the Strait of Hormuz is important."

The joint statement on Hormuz freedom of navigation aligns with Seoul's simultaneous Cabinet approval of the expanded Cheonghae unit mandate, reinforcing the diplomatic groundwork for the deployment. **View on X**

FM Cho Hyun (@FMChoHyun), November 9

"Met Egyptian FM Badr Abdelatty in Paris on November 9, our fifth meeting. We discussed follow-up measures based on active high-level exchanges, including President Lee's Egypt visit last year and Egyptian President Al-Sisi's state visit to Korea last month. I requested Egypt's cooperation to resolve difficulties faced by Korean companies operating in Egypt."

The bilateral relationship was elevated to 'strategic partner' during Al-Sisi's October state visit to Seoul; the FM's public business-difficulty request signals active economic diplomacy alongside the security dialogue. **View on X**

US Ambassador to ROK (@USAmbROK), November 10

"Met with Fulbright Korea's Board to discuss how Fulbright educational exchanges can advance US-ROK strategic priorities. From shipbuilding and maritime cooperation to STEM innovation, Fulbright is connecting American and Korean talent to strengthen our economic security and Alliance."

The ambassador's explicit linkage of Fulbright exchanges to shipbuilding and economic security reflects the broader MASGA and maritime cooperation agenda prioritized in the US-Korea Strategic Trade and Investment Deal. **View on X**

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.

COMMENTARY

CSIS Press Briefing: Previewing President Trump's Trip to Asia. CSIS Korea Chair Victor Cha and colleagues briefed press on Trump's upcoming Asia trip, flagging the ASEAN Manila stop as the more consequential venue and cautioning that Trump's known reluctance to travel may shape the meeting's tone. The briefing also addressed how the Democratic midterm sweep changes the Congress variable for the alliance's remaining two Trump years, particularly on OPCON transfer conditions and security cooperation. (Victor Cha, CSIS experts, CSIS)

After the Midterms, Seoul and Washington Need a North Korea Policy That Outlasts Elections. The piece argues that party alignment between Seoul and Washington has historically been less important than the bipartisan consensus undergirding key alliance commitments. With Democrats gaining leverage over OPCON, joint exercises, and summit concessions, the author calls for structured bipartisan consultations to prevent North Korea policy from becoming hostage to electoral cycles. (The Diplomat, Diplomat)

12 PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

39%

0 pts vs Oct 13-15
Gallup Korea
October 27-29, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 7 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
35%	30%	28%

Gallup Korea publishes weekly; this reading is 1 week old (October 27-29, 2026).

13 THE WIRE

DPRK

Daily NK

North Korea moving top AI specialists from spy agency to foreign ministry

Central authorities ordered transfers from the Reconnaissance Information General Bureau to the Foreign Ministry beginning in late October 2026, stirring resentment inside the intelligence unit that groomed the experts.

NK News

US blacklists Seychelles-based crypto exchange over North Korean money laundering

The designation follows the US calling for coordinated action against North Korean cyber threats in the wake of the Binance hack attribution dispute.

Korea Times

Former US official: North Korea's nuclear-state recognition demand could block Trump-Kim summit

Former deputy secretary of state **Kurt Campbell** said North Korea has communicated that US recognition of its nuclear status is a precondition for a summit, complicating Trump's Asia-trip diplomacy.

US-KOREA

Pacific Forum

Pacific Forum: Three gaps persist in ROK wartime OPCON certification

Analysis identifies command authority, network rebuild (complete no earlier than 2029), and undefined cyber chain of command as the three unclosed gaps; the annual Security Consultative Meeting has slipped to early 2027.

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

CSIS

CSIS: 'Denuclearization' agenda at APEC trilateral talks risks overselling a deal

CSIS analysis argues the Trump administration should use the upcoming APEC margin talks with Putin and Xi to build a trilateral nuclear dialogue framework rather than pursue a formal denuclearization agreement neither party can deliver.

ROK POLITICS

Yonhap

Defense Minister Kang reiterates push to integrate three service academies into one institution

Kang Shin-chul met 60 cadets from Army, Navy, and Air Force academies at the Korea Military Academy; said the proposed National Military Academy's location remains under consideration.

14 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

No new reporting on any of the 11 monitored sites since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 230

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

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